

CRUIO

Creative Pipeline Platform

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Executive Summary

Cruio is a creative pipeline platform built for agencies, in-house creative teams, and production studios. It unifies the entire journey from pre-production brief to final published asset delivery into a single coherent system, replacing the five-to-seven disconnected tools that currently define creative production at scale.

The product name combines crew and I/O, reflecting the platform's core purpose: collaborative creative input and output through a structured, trackable pipeline.

Cruio's primary differentiator is always-on, contextual annotation tied directly to approval decisions. The review canvas has no annotation mode to enter. A click on any asset places a pin and opens a thread. The AI brand compliance system uses the same interaction. Every thread resolves into an approval or a revision request — the annotation IS the workflow, not a feature layered on top of it.

A second foundational differentiator is asset identity persistence. In Cruio, an asset exists once and runs many times. The same creative unit can deploy across multiple platforms, flight dates, and copy variants — all tracked as instances of the same asset — and carry forward into future campaign cycles with full lineage intact.

Capability	Current Landscape	Cruio
Asset Review & Annotation	Frame.io, Wipster, Filestage	Unified canvas — static + video, multi-asset, AI-flagged
Project & Task Management	Asana, Monday, Trello	Track-level workflow integrated with the review surface
Brand Compliance	Manual checks, PDF brand guide	AI compliance pins on the canvas, hard and soft flags
Publishing Records	Google Sheets, spreadsheets	Structured Run records attached to each asset
Recurring Campaign Memory	Start from scratch each cycle	Git-style flight branching with persistent asset lineage

SECTION 2

The Problem

Creative production at any serious scale is a coordination problem. A single campaign may involve a creative director, art director, photographers, motion designers, animators, a project manager, a marketer, and a client — working in different tools, at different times, with different levels of access to the work in progress.

Fragmentation Across Tools

The standard toolset for a campaign today:

- Briefs and storyboards live in Google Docs or Slides
- Raw assets are delivered via hard drive, Dropbox, or WeTransfer
- Review happens in Frame.io, email chains, or PDF annotations
- Tasks and timelines live in Asana, Monday, or a spreadsheet
- Publishing records are tracked manually in Google Sheets
- Brand guidelines are a PDF no one has updated in two years

Each handoff between tools is a potential failure point. Feedback disappears into email. Versions proliferate into filename chaos (hero_v4_FINAL_actually_final.jpg). The marketer has no visibility until the work is submitted for approval. The designer context-switches constantly between the work and the tools supposedly managing it.

No Memory Between Campaign Cycles

The most costly problem in recurring campaign production is the absence of institutional memory. When a monthly campaign cycles into its next flight, someone manually copies files, renames them, and tries to remember what ran previously. The team rebuilds context that should never have been lost. Performance data lives nowhere near the creative that generated it.

Brand Compliance Is Manual and Late

Most teams rely on a creative director's eye and a PDF brand guide to catch compliance violations. Hard rules — required legal disclaimers, logo clearspace, forbidden color combinations — are checked at the end of the process, when corrections are expensive. Soft rules — brand voice, visual consistency, tonal alignment — are rarely checked at all.

Approval Has No Structure or Memory

Review and approval in most tools is binary and stateless. A file gets shared. Someone comments. Someone else says approved somewhere in a Slack thread. Who approved? In what order? What was the compliance status? These questions get answered by digging through email history — or not answered at all.

SECTION 3

The Solution

Cruio replaces the fragmented tool landscape with a single adaptive platform organized around three phases of creative production: Pre-production, Iterations, and Publishing. These are not navigation tabs — they are a status rail, a visible indicator of where a project is. The actual workspace is two surfaces: the Project View (a deliverable grid) and the Review Canvas (the full-screen annotation and approval environment).

One Pipeline, All Media Types

Whether the deliverable is a photograph, a :30 video spot, an animated banner, or a static social graphic, the workflow is identical. Assets enter via upload, watch folder, or link ingest. They iterate through versions. They collect annotation threads. They pass through a structured approval chain. They publish to a structured run record. The canvas handles static and video automatically — the interaction model is the same.

Asset Identity, Not File Copies

A Cruio asset is a single persistent record. Its version history, annotation threads, compliance records, and published run instances all attach to that one identity. When a campaign cycles into its next flight, assets carry forward with their full lineage. What changed, what didn't, what ran where — visible at a glance without leaving the platform.

Annotation as the Workflow Engine

The review canvas is the product's core surface. Annotation is always on. A click places a pin and opens a thread. The AI compliance system places its findings the same way. Every thread requires a resolution: approval, revision request, or a formally overridden exception with a recorded reason. Approval state is the direct output of the annotation system.

SECTION 4

Core Product Philosophy

Phases Are Status, Not Navigation

Premiere Pro's Import / Edit / Export model is the failure case Cruio explicitly avoids. Once initial import completes, two of three tabs become useless. Cruio's three phases are a progress indicator, not a navigation destination. The interface never routes you to a phase — it shows you which phase the project is in.

One Interface, Role-Adaptive

There is one interface in Cruio. It adapts to the user's role and context without requiring them to learn a separate portal. A Founder sees portfolio-level health signals. A designer sees their annotation queue. A client sees only the assets shared with them. The shell is consistent. Density and permissions change.

The Canvas Gets the Screen

The review canvas is where the overwhelming majority of active work happens. Every design decision in Cruio flows from this principle: the canvas should be near-full-bleed, and anything that is not the asset should be subordinate to it. Panels collapse. Chrome is minimal. The asset gets the screen.

Records Are a Byproduct of Workflow

The compliance audit trail, publishing run history, version annotation record, and flight manifest are not produced by filling out forms. They are the automatic output of doing the work in Cruio. The record is generated by the workflow, not alongside it.

SECTION 5

The Workflow: Ingest to Publish

Pre-Production

A campaign begins within a client Org. A new Campaign is created. One or more Tracks are established: parallel workstreams for different production types (a commercial track, a banner track, a social track). Each Track contains Deliverables — individual assets with platform specs permanently attached at creation.

Campaign Resources are attached during pre-production: the creative brief, reference photography, storyboards, mood boards, props sheets, embedded links to external tools. These live in a collapsible panel accessible from within the canvas at any time. The Org's Brand Kit — colors, typography, logo lockups, copy guidelines, approved asset library — is the compliance source of truth, versioned with cutover dates for rebrands.

Iterations and Round-Based Approval

Each upload creates a new asset version automatically. No file renaming. No manual version tracking. When the art director judges a set ready for review, they submit a Round — a track-level submission event that snapshots the current version of every deliverable and notifies the approval chain.

Reviewers open the canvas and annotate. The AI compliance engine simultaneously checks the asset against the brand kit, placing hard flags (block approval until resolved) and soft flags (require human response). Assets unchanged from a prior round carry their previous approval forward. Only changed assets re-enter review. The round closes when all deliverables are approved or carried.

Publishing and Run Records

When a round closes, Publishing activates. Each approved asset is assigned one or more Runs: platform, flight dates, and copy. Cruio produces a Delivery Package — approved assets, per-asset run metadata, the flight manifest, and compliance sign-off records — as the structured handoff for media buyers and social managers. Cruio does not publish directly to ad platforms.

Flight Branching for Recurring Campaigns

Monthly or recurring campaigns branch like Git, initiated with a single gesture (analogous to WordPress clone-to-draft). A new flight inherits the prior flight's track structure and deliverable types. The art director updates what changed. Assets tag automatically as Carried (unchanged, approval inherited), Modified (new version, re-enters review), New (net new deliverable), or Retired (removed from this flight). The flight manifest is auto-generated — no spreadsheet required.

SECTION 6

Key Differentiators

Always-On Crosshair Annotation

No annotation mode. No Add Comment button. The cursor becomes a crosshair on hover over the asset. A click places a pin. This eliminates a mode-switch every competing tool requires. The AI compliance system uses the same mechanism. The annotation IS the review experience, not a feature attached to it.

Round-Based Group Approval With Carried Assets

Rounds solve the multi-asset approval problem. When a banner set has five sizes but only two changed between cycles, the three unchanged assets carry their prior approval forward. Reviewers only see what changed. The round has a clear record of every version reviewed, every approver, every decision.

Asset Identity and Campaign Memory

One persistent asset record. Many runs. Traceable lineage across cycles. The monthly campaign knows its full history. Expired assets (offer ended, license lapsed, platform policy triggered) are flagged at fork time, not discovered mid-flight. The delivery package is a structured record, not an email with attachments.

Compliance as Annotation

Brand compliance runs automatically on canvas entry and places findings as pins — the same interaction as human annotation. Hard violations block approval. Soft violations require response. The compliance record is permanent, per-asset, per-version. Audit-ready by design, not by request.

Unified Canvas for Static and Video

Static pins at (x, y). Video pins at (x, y, timecode). Same interaction, same sidebar thread list, same version tabs. For video, the timeline bar surfaces pin markers at their timecodes. Scrubbing to a pinned timecode makes that pin visible on the frame. Same model, extended coordinate system.

SECTION 7

Target Market and Go-to-Market Strategy

V1 Beachhead: Photography and Photo Studios

The strongest initial market is photographers and photo studios. Their workflow — brief, shoot, select, retouch, deliver — is the cleanest version of the full pipeline. High-volume asset sets, clear approval chains (photographer to art director to client), predictable deliverable structures. The compliance layer matters less in V1 for this segment; the review loop and approval chain are the primary value.

Photo studios provide an organic expansion path: they work for agencies and brands who will want to use Cruio for the full campaign pipeline, enabling natural growth from V1 to V2 without a cold-start in a new market segment.

V2 Expansion: Agencies and In-House Creative Teams

The full campaign workflow — multi-track, recurring flights, brand compliance — is the natural V2 target. Advertising agencies, digital marketing agencies, and in-house creative teams at mid-market brands have the fragmented tool problem most acutely and the budget to solve it systematically.

V3 Enterprise

Enterprise organizations with multiple brands, regional teams, and legal compliance requirements represent the long-term addressable market. The org-level brand kit, versioned compliance rules, full audit trails, and role-based permissions are designed with enterprise in mind even when not fully exposed in V1.

SECTION 8

Competitive Landscape

Tool	Strength	Gap	Cruio Advantage
Frame.io	Best-in-class video review	Video-first; no PM layer; no campaign memory	Unified static + video; full campaign pipeline; asset memory
Filestage / Ziflow	Multi-format review workflows	No versioning intelligence; no campaign structure	Round-based approval; flight branching; compliance engine
Wipster	Simple, accessible video review	Minimal feature set; no multi-asset management	Full campaign architecture; brand compliance layer
Asana / Monday	Strong project and task management	No creative canvas; no annotation; no asset identity	Canvas-native workflow; annotation as the approval engine
Google Drive / Docs	Universal access and familiarity	No review structure; no approval chain; no compliance	Structured pipeline; approval chain; AI compliance layer

No current tool combines creative asset review, project pipeline management, brand compliance checking, and campaign memory in a single coherent system. Cruio is not an incremental improvement on any existing tool — it is a new product category: the creative pipeline platform.

Business Model

SaaS, Seat-Based, Tiered by Org Complexity

Cruio operates on a subscription model anchored to active internal member seats. External collaborators — clients, freelancers, guest reviewers — are included up to reasonable thresholds without additional per-seat cost, aligning pricing with organizational value rather than penalizing collaboration.

Tier	Target Customer	Included
Starter	Solo photographers, freelancers	1 org, limited projects, core canvas, basic approval chain
Studio	Small studios, 2-10 members	Unlimited projects, video canvas, rounds, brand kit upload
Agency	10-50 members, multi-client orgs	Multiple orgs, AI compliance engine, flight branching, API
Enterprise	50+ members, multi-brand	SSO, advanced audit logs, SLA, dedicated support, custom compliance rules

Expansion Revenue

Expansion follows natural org growth: studios grow into agencies, agencies grow into enterprise clients. The architecture supports this path without migration friction. A solo photographer on Starter becomes a studio principal on Studio without re-onboarding. The pricing model compounds with the team.

Vision and Roadmap

V1: Core Review Loop

V1 targets photo studios with the core review experience: the canvas, always-on annotation, approval chain, basic round structure, and brand kit document upload. Flight branching in simplified form. Light-mode interface, minimal chrome, fast interactions. The goal is one workflow, end to end, without friction.

V2: Full Campaign Pipeline

V2 introduces multi-track campaigns, video canvas with timecoded annotations, the complete round system with carried approvals, structured Run records, flight branching with auto-generated manifests, and the AI compliance engine for structural and copy checking. Agency and in-house team targeting begins.

V3: Intelligence and Enterprise Scale

V3 introduces visual brand compliance (AI-calibrated on approved asset history), creative performance analytics by flight and platform, enterprise permission and audit tooling, API access for media buying platform integration, and machine-readable delivery packages for ad ops workflows.

The Long-View Position

Cruio's long-term position is the system of record for creative production. The same way a CRM is the system of record for customer relationships, Cruio becomes the place where every creative decision, approval, compliance check, and publishing record lives — permanently attached to the work it describes. Creative teams stop starting from scratch. Institutional knowledge compounds. The platform becomes more valuable with every campaign cycle.